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AI data analyst startup
Julius nabs \$10M seed
round

Julius AI, a startup that describes itself as an AI data analyst, announced it has raised a [\\$10 million seed round](#) led by Bessemer Venture Partners.

Horizon VC, SVF, Y Combinator, and the A16Z accelerator participated in the round, along with several high-profile angel investors, including Pivotal CEO Aravind Srinivas,

Veritas AI founder Lawrence

Founder Paul from Y Combinator's startup program.

Julius is designed for visualizing and modeling from functionality Claude, and niche. The code generates m

"The easiest told TechCrunch like you would a human, wo

Questions that include: "Can correlate for different industries in China versus US?"

Julius' specialization in data science even caught the eye of Harvard Business School (HBS) professor Iavor Bojinov last year. Bojinov was so impressed he asked Sonwalkar to modify Julius specifically for HBS' new required course called [Data Science and AI for Leaders](#).

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Marina Temkin

Reporter, Venture | X

Marina Temkin is a venture capital and startups reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining TechCrunch, she wrote about VC for...

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AI



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"I wanted to build something that would make data science very accessible to everyone," Sonwalkar told TechCrunch.

While some of Julius' functionality is also available on ChatGPT, Anthropic's Claude, and Google's Gemini, Iavor Bojinov, an assistant professor at Harvard Business School (HBS), liked the tool so much that he had to convince Sonwalkar to modify Julius specifically for HBS' new required course called Data Science and ML for Business.



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"We had done a lot of platforms, but performing the

The adoption by HBS, an educational institution that breeds about 1,000 future business leaders annually, is clearly a big win for Julius, which is currently a team of 12 employees.

Sonwalkar has also raised a seed round led by Bessemer Venture Partners' Talia Goldberg, TechCrunch learned from someone familiar with the deal. But Sonwalkar wouldn't discuss the details.

Bessemer didn't respond to a request for comment.

Did Sonwalkar's "Rahul Ligma" stunts open doors when he was first building Julius?



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"A little bit in the early days, but to be honest, not as much recently," he said.

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People are benchmarking AI by having it make balls bounce in rotating shapes



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Tested 9 AI models on a physics simulation task: rotating triangle + bouncing ball. Results:

- 🏆 Deepseek-R1
- 🥈 Sonar Huge
- 🥉 GPT-4o

AI



Google takes on ChatGPT's Study Mode with new 'Guided Learning' tool in Gemini

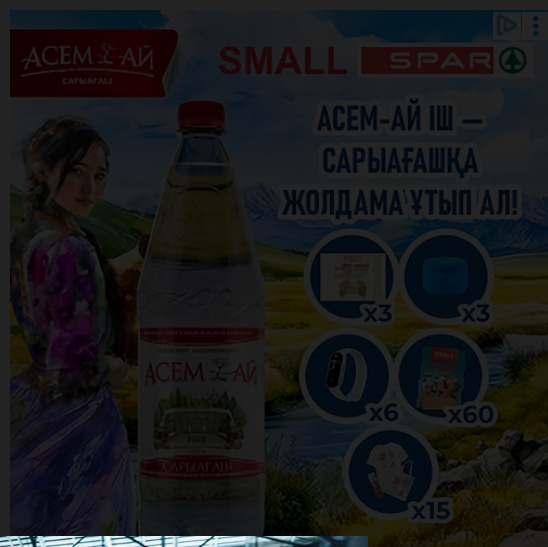
Aisha Malik · 14 hours ago

Worst? OpenAI o1: Completely misunderstood the task 😊

Video below ↓ First row = Reasoning models, rest = Base models. pic.twitter.com/EOYrHvNazr

— Aadhithya D (@Aadhithya_D2003) January 22, 2025

But what does it prove that an AI can or can't code a rotating, ball-containing shape?



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Well, simulation challenge. A detection algorithm (e.g. a ball and algorithms can obvious physics

X user N8 Programs

Nous Research

a bouncing ball in a rotating heptagon from scratch. "One has to track multiple coordinate systems, how the collisions are done in each system, and design the code from the beginning to be robust," N8 Programs explained in a [post](#).

But while bouncing balls and rotating shapes are a reasonable test of programming skills, they're not a very empirical AI benchmark. Even slight variations in the prompt can — and do — yield different outcomes. That's why some users on X report having more luck with [o1](#), while others say that R1 [falls short](#)

If anything, viral tests like these point to the intractable problem of creating useful systems of measurement for AI models. It's often difficult to tell what differentiates one model from another, outside of [esoteric benchmarks](#) that aren't relevant to most people.

Many efforts are underway to build better tests, like the [ARC-AGI benchmark](#) and [Humanity's Last Exam](#). We'll see how those fare — and in the meantime watch GIFs of balls bouncing in rotating shapes.

Topics: [AI](#) [AI](#) [ai benchmarks](#) [coding](#) [programming](#)



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